were able to provide as Ganjam itself was known for its rice fields. Earthwork was another sector where the Ganjamis excelled and, according to one general manager of the Burmah Oil Company in the 1930s, the native Burmese efficiency level in earthwork was only 60 per cent that of the Odiya migrant worker.[32]

Ganjam district, part of the Madras Presidency, was predominantly Odiya-speaking but also had a fair share of Telugu speakers as it lay at the border of modern-day Odisha and Andhra Pradesh. Migration was prevalent across both these language groups and a variety of castes: Brahmins, Kalingis, Kapus, Malas, Velamas, Bavuris, Kollas and more. Migrants' social networks would often transcend caste barriers as entire villages were depopulated of men of working age. Between 1911 and 1921, the district experienced negative population growth rates on account of extensive migration. Over 5 per cent of its population was found to be working in Burma.[33] However, Ganjami outmigration rarely led to permanent settlement in Burma with departures occurring between October and December and return migrations observed between March and May. But in many sectors, migrants would return only after three or four years of work.[34] Remittances served as a lifeline for the district, increasing during times of distress induced by natural disasters.[35]

The turmoil in Burmese politics ejected the Indians out of the country in the middle of the 20th century, causing Ganjami migrants to seek new destinations. They would eventually turn a full 360 degrees, to the west coast of the Indian subcontinent. Gujarat replaced Burma and Surat replaced Rangoon as the city of disembarkation. The Gopalpur–Rangoon steamer line gave way to the Puri–Okha Express that snaked its way across India, covering over 2500 km in fifty-odd hours.

How or when this switch occurred remains a bit of a mystery. In the 1970s, there were migrants who were referred to as 'malias' in Surat, suggesting that they were first employed in the gardening and horticulture sector.[36] But by the end of the 20th century, they were firmly located in the powerloom sector in the city, weaving synthetic *kapda* (cloth) amidst clanging machines in small *karkhana*s (workshops). Today, even the most